"My whole career is like a movie," says rapper and singer AP Dhillon when asked to pick the biggest highlight of his journey so far. The Canada-based Indian musician, who's currently one of the world's biggest Punjabi pop stars, told INDIA TODAY during a visit to Mumbai to promote his recently released Amazon Prime documentary series *First of a Kind,* that he hasn't "had the time to sit back and take it all in". The four-part series chronicles his remarkable rise to fame over the last four years.

Dhillon sums up his accomplishments, which include over five billion streams on music streaming platforms and being the first Punjabi musician to perform at the Junos, the Canadian equivalent of the Grammys, as "things that we did to make our people proud".

As with most documentaries in which the subject has an element of creative control—Dhillon is credited as an executive producer—*First of a Kind* shows us mostly what he wants us to see, but nevertheless gives us a glimpse into the personality of the man born Amritpal Singh Dhillon, who immigrated to Vancouver from Gurdaspur to study accounting and forge a better life for his family back home. It is, in fact, the first time the public at large gets to hear him speak, given that until the release of the documentary, he had declined all requests for press interviews.

LAST YEAR, DHILLON WAS THE SIXTH MOST STREAMED ARTIST ON SPOTIFY IN INDIA AND HAD FIVE HITS IN THE YEAR-END TOP 10 ON APPLE MUSIC

Dhillon and his crew, which includes fellow rapper-singers Gurinder Gill and Shinda Kahlon and producer Gminxr, are known to do the opposite of what most fast-rising acts do: they've said no to multiple Bollywood offers, and for a brief period, took down their songs from Indian audio-streaming services.

Success was relatively quick though not overnight for Dhillon, who says he was turned away by every label he approached. Undeterred, he started his own company, Run-Up Records, through which he put out over a dozen singles before the song 'Brown Munde' belatedly broke through in India in early 2021. The track went viral, thanks to its infectious chorus that celebrated South Asian identity. It was followed by 'Insane' and 'Excuses', dance-friendly tunes that certified his status as the hottest new act in the Indian music scene. More importantly, he heralded a brand new sound for Punjabi pop that traded bhangra-infused beats for the slick hip-hop-influenced production style of the West while retaining the lyricism and swag of the genre.

The decision to remove their music from local platforms was strategic, reveals Kevin Buttar, the Canada-born Indian who co-manages Dhillon along with his childhood friend Herman Atwal. "We saw that Spotify had just come into India at that time," says Buttar. "We wanted a big presence there and on Apple Music. We just drove all our fans towards those platforms as much as we could." Last year, Dhillon was the sixth most streamed artist on Spotify in India, and the highest ranked act without a connection to the film industry. On Apple Music, he had five hits in the year-end top ten in India for 2022.

His management and he were quick to capitalise on the massive streaming numbers by staging tours of India and North America in 2021 and 2022, respectively, while Dhillon's growing popularity earned him a slot at the inaugural edition of Lollapalooza India in Mumbai this January. But his team remained resistant to offers from film producers, and are rumoured to have turned down crores for 'Brown Munde'. "This one guy told me, 'I'll give you my Lamborghini'," says Buttar. "AP was like, tell him to give one to everybody on the team." Dhillon says that they just haven't

